



Bringing critical masculinity studies into a gender-inspired paradigm

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Recent disciplinary debates around the future of work and employment sociology have been based on the supposition that the sub-field has been in decline, coopted by business schools with their less ‘critical’ focus on the world of work and hence undermining the sociological base of such study. In parallel, the controversial ‘end-of-work’ thesis has signalled, potentially, a declining relevance of work as a source of identification, differentiation and cohesion. Taken together, these suggestions and debates spell out a challenge to work and employment sociology both in terms of an established disciplinary location within business/management schools and in terms of suggestions of a more peripheral positioning of work in everyday lives. Kate Huppatz and Anne Ross-Smith’s article is a welcome addition to the controversies surrounding the so-called ‘crisis’ in the field through a possible fragmentation along theoretical and methodological lines – a fragmentation that could potentially undermine a cohesive, critical focus on the politics of working life. They offer an optimistic ‘way forward’ through the deployment of the gender and work sub-field. As they argue convincingly, this sub-field is capable of integrating, through its interdisciplinary orientation as well as its focus on mainstream sociological issues, the different strands of analysis from both sociology and business/management schools, offering new frameworks for inquiry.

Through the incorporation of four key themes within gender and work sociology that relate to institutional, contextually driven practice; to wider social concerns including culture, class, violence and asymmetries of power; to lived, bodily experiences and to normative questions of equality, the authors argue innovatively for a ‘gender-inspired’ paradigm that has been overlooked within the end-of-work thesis as well as, arguably, within the debates about the future of work and employment sociology more widely. This not only enables critical examination of the ‘crisis’ debate as being potentially

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unfounded but also illustrates the significance of labour – both paid and unpaid – and of new forms of work for individual identities and collective experience.

While I welcome the view that gender and work scholarship has much to offer in bringing together a more fragmented field and in opening up new avenues of inquiry, I feel an opportunity may have been missed to further strengthen the argument through the inclusion of critical masculinity studies – a key strand within gender and work sociology that speaks powerfully to many of the issues raised. While Huppertz and Ross-Smith make reference to men's experiences, their account of gender scholarship tends to be 'skewed' towards feminist theorizing and the need to include the voices of women. In other words, the compelling case presented here for a gender paradigm would, in my view, be given greater strength and impetus through the inclusion of critical masculinity studies which sits alongside, but which needs to be differentiated from, feminist theories with their primary focus on women's accounts and experiences. With its interdisciplinary, critical orientation, and with a location within both sociology and management/organization studies, critical masculinity studies has built on feminist scholarship to address some of the issues and concerns raised by the 'sociology of work in crisis' thesis. In seeking to explore and explain the 'politics of privilege' as manifest in organizations and the world of work, this literature is centrally connected to the four, highly relevant strands identified in Huppertz and Ross-Smith's article as foundational for a gender-based paradigm: gendered practice and the centrality of work to masculine identities (e.g. Connell, 2000); differentially experienced levels of privilege and disadvantage through the intersections of gender race and class in terms of the politics of the 'centre' and the margins (e.g. Slutskaya et al., 2015); masculine embodiments (and disembodiments) in the context of work (e.g. Hall et al., 2007); notions of 'crisis' in masculinity through specific sectoral decline and more generalized understandings of female ambition and 'success' within a contemporary postfeminist gender regime (e.g. O'Neill, 2015) as well as shifting lines of privilege, equality and inequality as, for example, 'femininity' and 'feminine practices' are 'coopted' and given greater value by being brought into the masculine domain (e.g. Pullen and Simpson, 2009). These and other contemporary issues have particular significance for, and powerful resonance with, work and employment sociology, as well as for those seeking to challenge the 'end-of-work' thesis, through the adherence within the field to the centrality of work for understanding lived experiences and through its critical focus on the politics of work-based inclusion and exclusion.

In short, in wholeheartedly endorsing the deployment of gender and work scholarship as a potentially innovative 'way forward' in the repositioning of work and employment sociology – and in the spirit of further strengthening an already compelling account – I suggest critical masculinity studies, with its theoretical and empirical focus on power relations, can offer a further potential solution to the 'discipline in crisis' debate as well as strong challenge to arguments relating to a lack of criticality and 'fragmentation' within the field.

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Author biography

Ruth Simpson is Professor of Management at Brunel Business School. Her research interests include gender and organizations; inequality and 'dirty work'; and gender and careers. She has authored, co-authored and co-edited several books including *Gendering Emotions in Organizations* (2007); *Men in Caring Occupations: Doing Gender Differently* (2009); *Emotions and Transmigration* (2011); *Dirty Work: Concepts and Identities* (2012); and *The Handbook of Gender in Organizations* (2014). She has had several editorial roles and has published in leading journals including *Human Relations*, *Organization*, *Work*, *Employment and Society*, *The Academy of Management (Learning and Education)*, *Management Learning* and *Gender, Work & Organization*.